COUNTRY REPORTS: SIERRA LEONE

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Status report

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The government's answer to the mobile-money fraud wave of 2026, the most pressing digital-policy question of the year, is coordination rather than rules. A two-day national workshop on 18 and 19 August 2026 brought the Bank of Sierra Leone, the communications regulator, operators, cybersecurity bodies and civil society together to draft a coordination roadmap, and the measures announced were public awareness and better inter-agency working rather than any new legal instrument. A multi-agency strategy announced on 5 August 2026 — awareness, institutional strengthening, better investigation — likewise proposes no liability rule, refund duty or new operator obligation.

The overarching document remains the National Innovation and Digital Strategy 2019-2029, published by the Ministry of Communication, Technology and Innovation, which carries interoperability standards, e-government and data exchange as pillars inside itself rather than in strategies of their own, and commits that cognitive, mental, literacy or physical ability should not exclude anyone from digital services. Delivery sits with that ministry and the Directorate of Science, Technology and Innovation, anchored in the Medium-Term National Development Plan and the "Big Five Game Changers". The National Monitoring and Evaluation Agency tracks implementation of the National Development Plan 2024-2030 and supplies Cabinet with technical appraisals ahead of major decisions (August 2026).

Below that sit the sector documents. The central bank's National Strategy for Financial Inclusion 2022-2026 sets targets for women, youth, rural communities and smaller enterprises. Cabinet approved the country's first National Data Protection Policy in April 2026, authorising repeal of the Right to Access Information Commission Act. A first national artificial-intelligence strategy is being developed with the World Bank, none being in force. The procurement authority's chief executive has positioned public procurement as "a key foundation for effective e-governance" (August 2026), and the communications regulator is pressing for fifteen- to twenty-year spectrum licences and staggered spectrum fees as the terms for rural expansion (March 2026).

The pace of governance reform behind all this has slowed: Sierra Leone scores 53.0 out of 100 for overall governance, 23rd of 54, after a rise of only 1.1 points across the most recent five years (2023). A national roadmap against mobile-money fraud was validated at the close of a workshop on 18 and 19 August 2026.

Legislation and regulation

Sierra Leone's principal communications statute reaches only the people it licenses: every enforcement power the National Communications Authority Act 2022 gives the regulator — compliance orders, sanctions, licence revocation, consumer obligations and data-protection duties — opens with the words "a licensee", so it binds an

operator such as Orange and reaches neither the fraudster nor an unlicensed foreign platform. The Act defines "intermediary service provider" in its opening section in terms that fit a messaging platform, then never uses the term again across its thirty-eight Parts, so the definition carries no duty and no power.

The books are otherwise reasonably full. The National Civil Registration Act 2016 makes registration compulsory for citizens and residents alike and provides the legal basis for national identification numbers and multipurpose identity cards, with a Cabinet directive since making the number a condition of access to public and financial services, enforced more firmly from January 2025. The National Payment Systems Act 2022 lets the central bank organise, own and operate payment and settlement systems rather than merely regulate them, and creates a National Payment System Committee seating mobile money operators, community banks and the Fintech Association. The Cyber Security and Crime Act 2021 supplies the offences an account-takeover engages — illegal access, data interference, computer-related forgery and identity fraud. The draft Companies and Business Registration Bill 2026 would mandate a one-stop shop with a centralised electronic database and legally required sharing with the revenue authority, social security and municipal licensing.

The holes are in what is not yet enacted and in who answers for what. The Data Protection and Right to Access Information Bill 2025 would create a single independent authority for both data protection and access to information, a body the country does not have. Mobile money is supervised by the communications regulator "together with the Bank of Sierra Leone", with no lead named and no memorandum between them. Subscribers regulations tying every SIM to its holder's identification number were announced in July 2026 and take effect after a six-month transition, with operators fined 25,000 new leones for every unregistered or pre-activated card. Much of this could move without Parliament: the 2022 Act empowers the regulator to make statutory instruments. A Digital Government Bill was being drafted with the Attorney-General's office in September 2026, and a public-private dialogue was convened on 27 and 28 July 2026 to operationalise the Electronic Transactions Act 2019.

Data protection

Sierra Leone has no economywide data-protection statute, and what stands in its place is the telecommunications licensing framework. Under those sectoral rules consent is required before personal data may be processed, subscriber data must be held in a central electronic database inside the country — a localisation mandate carried in licence conditions rather than in a privacy law — and personal data may not be transferred out of the country without the telecoms regulator's approval. Those duties bind licensees; they do not reach a controller who holds no licence.

The statute has been close for a year. The combined Data Protection and Right to Access Information Bill completed its final national validation in November 2025, and Cabinet's approval of a first National Data Protection Policy in April 2026 left the Bill with the Attorney-General's office for tabling in Parliament, no data protection or localisation law being yet in force. Until it passes there is no supervisory authority to complain to, and the World Bank identifies the missing framework as undermining safe use of the national identity system (December 2025).

The gaps are concrete. No law requires a payment service provider to notify users or a regulator of a data breach within a set period: the National Payment Systems Act 2022 imposes general consumer disclosure duties and no breach-notification duty. Sharing of identity data rests on the disclosure provisions of the National Civil Registration Act 2016 plus bilateral memoranda — with the road safety authority, and with banks for electronic know-your-customer checks — rather than on any comprehensive national framework, and the registration authority itself called in August 2026 for governance standards over how registration data moves between institutions, separating integration from unrestricted access.

The state reaches subscriber records at volume: Orange Sierra Leone answered more than 18,000 police requests for know-your-customer data to support criminal investigations (August 2026). Customers carry the corresponding risk on their own — the loss from an authorised push payment falls on them, there are no statutory SIM-swap safeguards, and the only practical route to recovery is a discretionary freeze by the operator. A three-day workshop on guardrails for children's data in public infrastructure was reported on 10 September 2026.

Regional collaboration

Sierra Leone's borders are more open to its neighbours' networks than to their systems. A free-roaming memorandum with Liberia and The Gambia took effect in phases from 2 May 2025, first between Liberia and Sierra Leone and from 1 July 2025 for travel to and from The Gambia under the ECOWAS roaming framework, letting subscribers use a home SIM at local rates, and the communications regulator signed a further free-roaming agreement with Guinea in November 2025 under Smart Africa's single digital market programme — the second Sierra Leone-Guinea telecoms pact inside a year. Physically the country is knitting in too, through a fibre interconnection with Guinea at Pamelap, a four-country consortium agreed in June 2026 to commercialise spare fibre on the TRANSCO CLSG power grid, and the second West Africa Regional Digital Integration Project approved in March 2026 with Benin and Liberia.

Identity is where recognition stops short of use. Sierra Leone issues an ECOWAS-compliant biometric card that works as a regional travel document, without cross-border authentication of the identity behind it. As an ECOWAS member state it falls within the cross-border interoperability strategy and 2026 work plan validated in March 2026 by the regional identification programme's supervisory committee, which commits the region to mutual recognition of national ID credentials and harmonised technical specifications for foundational systems; the strategy is validated rather than operating. The area over which recognition could run has shrunk: Burkina Faso, Mali and Niger severed ECOWAS and programme ties in 2024 and launched a common Alliance of Sahel States biometric passport in January 2025.

Money reaches the region through banks rather than wallets: nine Sierra Leonean banks are live send-and-receive participants in the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System, and no mobile money operator is among them (June 2026). Sierra Leone's own minister was at the table when ECOWAS adopted the regional Digital Sector Development Strategy 2024-2029 at Cotonou on 4 October 2024. What the region does not do is pay for it: the ECOWAS Community budget for 2026-2028 carries no disaggregated digital or ICT appropriation, and its only ICT-named programme line shows nil actual spending from 2024 through the 2028 estimates. Sierra Leone says it has tabled a regional data embassy framework at ECOWAS (September 2026), with no text published. Practical cooperation is bilateral: the procurement authority sent a delegation to Liberia's procurement commission on 6 and 7 August 2026 to study its electronic government procurement platform.

Standards

The one general standards gate the state operates is a Digital Service Compliance review process run by the Ministry of Communication, Technology and Innovation for government digital solutions (2025). It sits above very little common plumbing: the core public financial management systems run as standalone systems with no government service bus and no universally agreed protocols between them (2025), and an Interoperability Roadmap completed under the Ministry of Finance's reform programme sets up an X-Road pilot rather than a framework already in force.

Where standards do bind, they are sectoral and mostly borrowed from outside. The national identity system is being migrated onto the open-source MOSIP platform, a brownfield migration of records already enrolled, and the ministry names that platform as the specification the wider digital public infrastructure programme is layered on (August 2026); the credentials envisaged with Bhutan's national digital identity body are W3C-compliant verifiable

credentials. The audit office's new management system is a localisation of the regional AFROSAI-E audit platform, in the last stage of user acceptance testing rather than production (August 2026), and is expected to standardise audit practice across planning, risk assessment, quality assurance and reporting. The planned national mortality system is designed to adopt the World Health Organization's ICD-11 cause-of-death classification.

Financial rulemaking is standardised in form but not in publication: rules for the national payment switch are issued as central bank directives, which the National Payment Systems Act 2022 requires to appear in the Gazette or on the Bank's website at least fifteen days before taking effect, and no consolidated public rulebook exists.

Service quality is only now acquiring a standard to be held to. The communications regulator announced network drive tests and fines for network-quality lapses alongside a new phase of SIM registration (August 2026). On the spending side, Sierra Leone launches upwards of a hundred public projects a year and none was monitored by a dedicated body until the National Monitoring and Evaluation Agency was created; it is now expanding a platform giving authorised staff real-time metrics on those projects.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The index that ranks Sierra Leone second of 54 African states for deliberative and participatory governance, at 81.1 out of 100 after a rise of 23.9 points over 2014-2023, also records digital freedom among the country's ten most deteriorated measures, down 7.9 points to 79.8 (2023). Consultation is widening while the conditions for it narrow.

The formal freedoms remain strong on paper and weaker in the experience of them: freedom of expression and belief scores 89.2 out of 100, 6th of 54 and essentially unchanged over the decade, while the public's own sense of freedom of speech sits at 63.3, 20th of 54, and media freedom scores 65.6, 12th of 54, having slipped 2.6 points (2023). Freedom of association and assembly sits near the bottom of the same index.

Within digital policy specifically the consultation is real and recent. An eighteen-month engagement with the Digital Impact Alliance brought more than 220 stakeholders, civil society among them, into the shaping of the Digital Economy Programme and the National Data Strategy, the communications ministry convened a national dialogue on digital identity and digital public infrastructure on 5 August 2026 and calls it the first of a series, and the artificial-intelligence strategy process ran multi-stakeholder consultations that seek to reflect the country's local languages and cultural contexts. The fifth Open Government Partnership action plan, running to June 2028, commits Parliament and civil society to build a portal for public comment on draft legislation, not yet built when it was reviewed in February 2025.

Disagreement is aired rather than managed. Parliament took up the mobile-money fraud wave on 4 August 2026, the Speaker demanding a remedial plan from the Communications Minister and the Opposition and Majority Leaders calling for oversight hearings and refunds for victims, with the House resolving that its Communications Committee report within a month and adopting no liability rule at the sitting. Days earlier a former minister had argued publicly that the problem is unenforced law rather than absent law. The head of the civil registration authority has warned publicly against parallel identity systems being built alongside its own.

What the public cannot readily obtain is the record to argue from: disclosure and accessibility of public records both score poorly and have barely moved over the decade (2023).

Finance

Financial sustainability

Sierra Leone's treasury carries almost all of its digital lines, and most of that money is the communications regulator's: the 2026 estimates vote NLe401.7m for the regulator's operations, against NLe22.0m for the civil registration authority's identity-system project (2026).

The state's own money is 88.6% of the digital lines of the 2026 estimates, NLe637.3m of NLe719.0m, against 94.7% in 2024.

The external part is almost all one loan: a foreign loan for school connectivity carries NLe80.6m in 2026, and a World Bank grant to the Digital Transformation Project NLe1.06m, against NLe30.0m for the school-connectivity loan in 2024. That project, US$50m from the World Bank, closes on 30 September 2027 and had disbursed 21.24% by August 2025, and the 2025 estimates carried a NLe0.5m government counterpart for it. What is voted is spent and more: in 2025 the regulator's line paid out NLe425.0m against NLe323.0m voted and NLe401.0m after the mid-year revision, and the identity-system project NLe18.6m of NLe20.0m.

The sector's own-source mechanisms are in law and leak. A universal access and service levy of 0.75% of operators' gross income, alongside parliamentary appropriations and grants, finances the Universal Access Development Fund, but 10 of 16 internet service providers paid no levy for 2024 and the auditor found no penalty imposed on them. The regulator's revenue rose 46% in 2024 on surcharges under the Finance Act 2024, and it paid NLe74.7m, 12% of that revenue, into the Consolidated Revenue Fund.

The one private arrangement with money attached is the state telco's: Africell handed Sierratel a US$2m upfront payment on 5 May 2026 under the partnership relaunching it as a mobile virtual network operator, the money going to settle long-standing staff liabilities.

MoUs and other agreements

The state telecoms operator is being handed to a competitor to run: in April 2026 the government appointed Africell as investment partner to relaunch the loss-making Sierratel as a mobile virtual network operator on a revenue-share model, avoiding heavy capital spending after earlier failed privatisation attempts and aiming at students and young professionals. No launch date, contract term or revenue split accompanies it.

Roaming is where the country's cooperation agreements reach subscribers directly. A free-roaming memorandum with Liberia and The Gambia under the ECOWAS roaming framework took effect between Liberia and Sierra Leone on 2 May 2025 and extended to The Gambia by 1 July 2025, letting subscribers use their home SIM at local rates. The National Communications Authority then signed a free-roaming agreement with Guinea on 17 November 2025 at Transform Africa 2025, under Smart Africa's Single Digital Market programme and the second Sierra Leone-Guinea telecoms pact inside a year, with no commencement date or tariff detail attached.

The rest are statements of intent carrying no figures. The Directorate of Science, Technology and Innovation and Catholic Relief Services signed a memorandum of understanding on geospatial technology in June 2026, with no value, duration or funding commitment set out. Cross-border payments firm Cauridor and BnB announced a partnership on 14 August 2026 to widen digital payments, mobile money and cross-border transfer access, building on Cauridor's existing links with Orange and MTN, and named no amount, product or delivery date. Pairing a public body with a private operator is the standing form of these arrangements - the government with Africell, the science directorate with a relief agency, payments firms with each other - rather than a mechanism any of them writes down.

New investments

The newest money is regional and unsplit: the World Bank approved the USD 137 million second West Africa Regional Digital Integration Project on 11 March 2026, covering Sierra Leone with Benin and Liberia for broadband and digital public services reaching around 10.6 million people across the three, with no national share set out.

The largest commitment to the country alone is the World Bank's USD 50 million concessional loan for the Digital Transformation Project (July 2022), running to 2027 across broadband, digital government systems, digital financial services and skills. Before it, China Eximbank lent RMB 207 million on concessional terms in August 2019 for Phase 2 of the national fibre optic backbone, 721.5 km across fifteen cities, on-lent to SALCAB and built by Huawei.

Two of the biggest figures are not money in but cover against loss: MIGA's USD 97.2 million political risk guarantee (2018) runs to 2033 over SONATEL's 50% stake in Orange Sierra Leone, and a USD 13.5 million guarantee (2021) covers solar-hybrid power at around 600 Orange tower sites. The Millennium Challenge Corporation's compact pays for a main and back-up distribution dispatch centre and a national dispatch centre with SCADA upgrades - electricity network control, with no identity or payments component.

Identity and civil registration have drawn little: the EU's EUR 5 million for civil registration infrastructure ran 2020-2025 and that window has closed. UNICEF and the Islamic Development Bank are connecting 523 schools under Giga Phase 2, the bank taking 403 and UNICEF 120. The African Development Bank has a governance and aid-coordination grant in pipeline with The Gambia, and two regional facilities name the country without sizing its part: bank identification and digital interoperability across the West African Monetary Zone and the SHyMeR grant to the West African Health Organization for a regional health data hub.

Twelve digital-sector commitments are on record as at August 2026, ten to Sierra Leone alone and two regional facilities naming it, starting from 2018 with windows out to 2033: six grants worth about USD 63 million, two concessional loans worth USD 84 million, and two MIGA guarantees covering USD 112 million of private investment (August 2026). The country-specific ones come to roughly a quarter of a billion US dollars, close to half of it guarantee cover rather than money flowing in, and three of the twelve are approved or in pipeline rather than under way. Connectivity takes much the largest share, electricity control systems next, every other subsector far behind. The African Development Bank appears most often, while the World Bank and the Millennium Challenge Corporation are the largest sources of finance that actually flows.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Sierra Leone's fibre backbone reached 14 of the country's 16 districts by April 2026, while internet use stood at 25.1% of the population in 2024. The split runs through every measure of the sector: mobile communications is the most improved of all 96 indicators the Ibrahim Index tracks for Sierra Leone, rising 41.0 points over 2014-2023 to 79.4 out of 100 and 12th of 54 African states, while access to internet and computers remains among its ten worst-scoring measures, at 24.8 out of 100. Building the network and getting people onto it are separate problems.

Price is the harder half. The government's own National Broadband Strategy places Sierra Leone 14th of 16 West African states on the cost of a gigabyte of mobile data. Coverage is no longer the constraint: the regulator puts Africell's network at just over 92% of the population for 2G, 77.48% for 3G and 61.72% for 4G (April 2026).

Sierra Leone has only one submarine cable landing, and a communications ministry delegation has assessed a second routed via Guinea. ECOWAS is separately advancing a second cable of its own: member-state experts with their technical and financial partners approved the feasibility study for a cable serving Cabo Verde, Liberia, Sierra Leone

and Guinea-Bissau at a Monrovia workshop in October 2025, with no route, cost, landing site or construction date published since. Land routes are filling in: Guinea's SOGEB and Sierra Leone's Leonecom interconnected their national fibre networks at the Pamelap border crossing in June 2025, giving cheaper regional transit and route redundancy, and in June 2026 the country joined Liberia, Guinea and Côte d'Ivoire in a consortium to commercialise spare fibre capacity on the TRANSCO CLSG power transmission grid, an alternative to the cable all four depend on. Michcom-IX, a carrier-neutral non-profit exchange, already interconnects networks in Guinea and Liberia as well as Sierra Leone, while the state's own exchange is further back: a feasibility study for a national internet exchange point was completed in August 2025, the exchange still at planning and procurement.

On the state's side, the World Bank-financed Digital Transformation Project is extending broadband to schools, hospitals, clinics and local government offices in secondary cities, and in April 2026 the government appointed Africell as investment partner to relaunch the loss-making state telco Sierratel as a mobile virtual network operator on a revenue-share model. SIM registration is being tied to the national identity number, with unregistered cards cut off in stages after a six-month transition (July 2026). The procurement review panel dismissed a bidder's complaint over the contract for the government wide and local area networks on 6 October 2026 and directed the ministry to open financial proposals and proceed to award.

Data Storage

The state acquired a data centre of its own in April 2026, when the National Data Centre was commissioned inside the National Communications Authority's new Freetown headquarters — a ten-storey building begun in 2015 that also houses the communications ministry and the regulator's network operations. It is not the only government platform: a separate government data centre supporting the e-Government Procurement system runs at the Ministry of Finance, its disaster-recovery arrangements still being finalised.

Everything else the country's data sits on is commercially owned. Orange Sierra Leone has run a data centre in Freetown since 2018, with capacity for 154 racks and opened a second, EUR 23 million facility at Bo on 29 November 2025; the Bo site is an identical replica of the Freetown one, built as a disaster-recovery hub for a capital exposed to landslide and recurrent flooding. Colocation is available independently of the operators: Afcom sells rack and cage space with redundant power and cooling to enterprise and government customers in Freetown, alongside smaller providers including Zoodlabs and Leonecom. Beyond that the country is a customer of somewhere else — there is no hyperscale cloud region in Sierra Leone, the nearest being Google's Johannesburg region.

Ownership is where the language around all this strains. Sonatel's chief executive called the Bo centre "a major step forward for data sovereignty" — a privately held building, owned by a foreign group, described as a national gain. What binds anyone to keep data in the country is narrow: subscriber data must be retained in a central electronic database inside Sierra Leone, a requirement carried in the telecoms licensing framework rather than in a privacy law, so it reaches what a licensee holds and nothing else. The general rule is still being written — Cabinet approved the country's first National Data Protection Policy in April 2026, with the bill being finalised for Parliament.

Energy

Access to energy is one of Sierra Leone's three lowest-scoring measures in the Ibrahim Index, at 12.7 out of 100 and 47th of 54 African states, having gained 4.8 points over 2014-2023 — the same decade in which the country's mobile score climbed faster than any other indicator it tracks. Just over a quarter of the population had electricity in 2020, and the shortfall falls where every other digital shortfall falls: 56.3% of urban residents had electricity in 2023 against 19.0% of rural ones, a gap of 37.3 percentage points. Supply to those who have it is severely unreliable. Renewable sources accounted for 75.28% of electricity generation in 2021.

Policy has largely given up on waiting for the grid to arrive. The national electrification plan runs on decentralised supply — mini-grids and stand-alone solar systems, backed by dedicated programmes and duty exemptions. The World Bank is financing solar home systems for 500 schools and 200 health facilities so they have the electricity digital services need, and the mobile network has been doing the same for itself: solar-hybrid power is being installed at around 600 Orange Sierra Leone tower sites, cutting diesel use by three-quarters.

Where power is absent the digital estate simply does not run. Inadequate and unreliable electricity, limited connectivity and a shortage of computers and printers are what the police give as the barriers to digitising case records, and they bear hardest on rural stations. In rural clinics the same combination of unreliable power and connectivity keeps paper the primary medium for patient records. The RESPITE solar and storage plant was commissioned in July 2026 and is fully operational.

Technical Capacity

Public administration scored 53.9 out of 100 in the 2023 Ibrahim Index, 27th of 54 African states, and rose only 1.6 points over 2014-2023 — one of the two smallest gains among the index's sixteen sub-categories — while effective administration reached 60.3, 19th of 54 and up 8.3 points. The state is running its existing machinery better than it is growing the machinery, and the difference shows in what it can build for itself.

The identity system is the clearest case. The National Civil Registration Authority manages it domestically but depends on external technology partners for its core components, with the India-based MOSIP foundation supplying the open-source platform and a local firm producing the biometric cards under a public-private partnership, and its own officials describe the constraint on any replacement as having to match the legacy system's service delivery from the first day, because institutions already rely on the register. Elsewhere the difficulty is operational rather than architectural: the agency running the national project monitoring platform acknowledges continuing problems with data entry and reporting.

The pipeline behind all of this is narrow. Tertiary ICT and engineering capacity rests on a small number of public institutions, principally the University of Sierra Leone and Njala University.

Cybersecurity

Two state systems were breached within a fortnight: the communications ministry confirmed that 44 website addresses were hit on 25 September 2026 by unauthorised access to the system that administers the national internet domain, restored the same day, and the road safety authority disclosed, in a notice dated 2 October 2026, an unauthorised intrusion into the systems used to produce vehicle licences, with five arrests.

The government's principal instrument against the 2026 wave of mobile-money fraud is an identity control rather than a security one: in a ministerial statement in August 2026 it named the linking of SIM cards to national identification numbers as its main enforcement lever, while conceding that not all subscribers have yet linked a SIM to a verified number. The Communications Minister confirmed to Parliament that cyber-enabled fraud — impersonation, phishing and bogus mobile-money requests — is growing.

Measured readiness is middling and institutional. Sierra Leone sits in the "establishing" tier of the ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, the band for overall scores of at least 55 out of 100. A National Cybersecurity Coordination Centre works alongside the communications ministry and the science and technology directorate on whole-of-government cyber and emerging-technology capacity, and senior officials across ministries, departments and agencies have been put through cybersecurity and emerging-technology training.

The regional obligation is dormant by its own terms. The ECOWAS directive on cyber and ICT confidence-building measures, adopted alongside the bloc's Digital Sector Development Strategy in October 2024, urges member states to implement it "without delay upon its publication" — a duty that begins when a text appears, not when ministers adopted it.

Domestic reach is the deeper limit. Every enforcement power the National Communications Authority Act 2022 gives the regulator opens with the words "a licensee", so it binds an operator such as Orange and reaches neither the fraudster nor the unlicensed foreign platform the fraud runs on, and no mandatory fraud data-sharing arrangement exists between the mobile-money operators, the Bank of Sierra Leone, the Financial Intelligence Unit and the police. What the state has put on the record since is public awareness, institutional strengthening and better investigation, with no liability rule, refund duty or new operator obligation, and a two-day workshop in August 2026 with the central bank, the regulator, operators and civil society to draft a coordination roadmap. The duty in the meantime sits with the operator: President Bio pressed telecommunications providers on their cybersecurity responsibilities at the Bo opening in November 2025, and Orange launched a scam-reporting service on its own network in August 2026. The communications ministry presented draft digital protection plans for four critical sectors in August 2026.

DPI

Data Exchange

Sierra Leone's interoperability roadmap is finished and the layer it describes does not exist: the Ministry of Finance's public financial management progress report for 2025, published in June 2026, records the Interoperability Roadmap as developed, with a Government Service Bus to be piloted on X-Road technology, the roadmap itself having been contracted to PCL International in April 2025 for completion by the end of September.

Nothing crosses it yet. A 2025 World Bank terms of reference records that there is no government service bus with universally agreed protocols across the public financial management estate, and that IFMIS, the Integrated Tax Administration System, ASYCUDA and the Bank of Sierra Leone's T24 core banking system run as standalone systems. A prototype bus is funded through a Japanese Quality Infrastructure Investment grant provided on 26 April 2025, and the systems named for connection to it are civil registration and vital statistics, the tax administration system, the local education management system LoMEMIS, the Municipal Property Tax System covering 22 local councils and T24. The tax system meanwhile runs interfaces of its own: the revenue authority has linked it to ASYCUDA World, the commercial banks and the civil registration system, though not directly, and waits on the National Investment Board to build the system that would join business registration to it.

What crosses institutional boundaries today does so through the identity register rather than a bus. The National Civil Registration Authority's verification platform lets banks, telecoms operators, social security, immigration, health and education bodies authenticate against the national database by API or web portal. A memorandum of understanding signed in May 2024 to establish a Data Exchange Layer for real-time sharing of identity and civil registration data with a line ministry has not become operational. Elsewhere the position is manual: the land register exchanges data with no other government system, and data sharing between the business register, the revenue authority, social security and municipal licensing is written into a bill rather than into a system.

There is no standalone data exchange strategy; interoperability sits as a pillar of the National Innovation and Digital Strategy 2019-2029. Data-sovereignty terms rest in telecoms licensing rather than privacy law, with subscriber data held in country and transfers abroad requiring the telecoms regulator's approval. The registration authority is

pressing for governance standards over sharing between institutions, separating system integration from unrestricted access. Consultations were held at the Jendema border post ahead of the customs system's extension there, reported 6 October 2026.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Fewer than half a million eID cards had been issued in Sierra Leone as of 2024 against a register holding the great majority of the population, the World Bank attributing the gap to a card fee of roughly six to seven US dollars in a country where most people live on less than $2.15 a day.

Registration itself is free and compulsory for citizens and residents alike under the National Civil Registration Act 2016, and is open from birth. The card is not: it costs NLe140 plus a NLe5 application fee for nationals aged 12 and over, more for ECOWAS and non-national cards.

The number does much of the work. A Cabinet Directive ratified by Parliament in March 2022 makes it a condition of financial services, education, healthcare, SIM registration, immigration and employment, with enforcement strengthened from January 2025 including identity checks at checkpoints; it has been mandatory for passports and work and residence permits since June 2022 and for driving licences and vehicle registration since the Road Safety Authority gained platform access in October 2023. The card is ECOWAS-compliant and serves as a regional travel document, though cross-border authentication is not established.

The register is being migrated onto the open-source MOSIP platform, begun with a pilot in early 2024; that pilot is complete and full implementation is unfunded (August 2026), and the authority's head has warned against parallel identity systems being built alongside its own.

Civil registration underneath is uneven. It is the country's strongest public administration measure in the Ibrahim Index, seventh of 54 African states in 2023 and unmoved since 2014, and birth registration completeness was 90.4% in the 2019 Demographic and Health Survey. Only a small fraction of deaths are fully registered, and the National Public Health Agency engaged suppliers on 7 August 2026 to build a national digital mortality registration and certification system. About 70% of the historic paper record base is still to be digitised (2025). Issuance remains concentrated at District Headquarters, and public perception of how easy it is to obtain an identity document fell 23.0 points to 27.2 out of 100 by 2023.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Sierra Leone has run real-time interoperable payments since February 2025 and has no rule on who bears the loss when one is misused: no law allocates loss for authorised push payment fraud, so it falls on the customer, and no statutory mechanism recalls or reverses a fraudulently induced transfer.

The Instant Payment Service launched in February 2025 with seven banks and two mobile money providers connected. It settles across the National Payment Switch, launched on 29 April 2023 and owned and operated directly by the Bank of Sierra Leone. Card rails now sit on wallets: Orange Money customers have had a virtual Mastercard since March 2026 and Afrimoney a prepaid Visa card since May 2026, obtainable without a bank account.

Adoption was measured at around 30% of adults in 2019, with 2.2 million active mobile money accounts after a 2020 clean-up; the central bank's National Strategy for Financial Inclusion 2022-2026 counted 6.5 million registered mobile money accounts in December 2021 and makes digital financial services a priority area. Access to banking services is the country's lowest-scoring measure of all 96 Ibrahim Index indicators, at 10.4 out of 100 in 2023.

Government is a partial user of its own rails: income and vehicle tax can be filed and paid by mobile money and wallet, and the revenue authority launched a mobile payment application in 2022 for non-tax revenue, but its payments out are only starting to move the same way: the flagship social assistance programme is shifting transfers to digital payments, and an emergency cash transfer reached 35,000 households by mobile phone, a national first (December 2025).

The central bank may own and operate as well as regulate under the National Payment Systems Act 2022, and the switch runs to central bank directives rather than a consolidated public rulebook. Supervision of mobile money is shared with the communications regulator with no lead named, the central bank's standalone consumer protection guidelines for all regulated institutions, drafted with UNCDF in 2020, still awaited public consultation in March 2021 and no issued version is on record, there is no mandatory fraud data-sharing arrangement between operators, the regulators and the police, and no statutory SIM-swap safeguards. A victim's only route is a discretionary operator freeze; Orange had logged about 390 mobile-money fraud complaints by early August 2026 and opened a Scam Alert reporting channel on 18 August 2026. Performance is reported in a recurring State of the Digital Financial Services Market report published with the UN Capital Development Fund. Distribution of smart goods and services tax machines to 10,000 businesses nationwide began on 31 August 2026.

Registries

Sierra Leone had no registered land ownership rights at all as of March 2022, against a target of 500,000 by 2028.

The land record is largely paper, with cadastral maps and deeds held manually across the Office of the Administrator and Registrar General and the Ministry of Lands, Housing and Country Planning; digitisation attempts in 2014 and 2016 did not progress and the Land Information System under the 2022-2028 land administration project is not operational. That project has moved past design, with a firm recruited to build the land information and cadastral system and records digitisation under way, but no public digital cadastre operates. Addressing has been built outside it: Freetown City Council has used Google Plus Codes as a digital address register since its 2019-2020 property tax reform, and a 2024 partnership between the Directorate of Science, Technology and Innovation and Google Maps extends digital addressing beyond the capital, though deployment stays urban.

The economic registers are the ones tied to the identity spine. The revenue authority runs the Integrated Tax Administration System as the digital taxpayer register, deployed nationwide with an online portal, and a taxpayer number requires the applicant's National Identification Number. The business register at the Office of the Administrator and Registrar-General offers online name search but is only partially digitised, with an online registration system under a 15-year concession ratified in May 2026, and it describes a small formal economy: the 2022 Census of Business Establishments counted 165,514 establishments, 71% of them informal.

Electoral and social registers draw on the population register directly. The voter roll is a fully digital biometric database extracted from civil-registry data and deployed at 3,300 centres for the June 2023 election, holding 3,374,258 voters against an estimated voting-age population of 4,690,201, and the electoral commission wants the two registers linked before the 2028 polls, with first-time voters completing civil registration first (August 2026). The national digital farmer registry is being authenticated against the identity number under an agreement of May 2025. Social protection is the thinnest: SPRINT, run by the National Commission for Social Action, supported around 65,000 extremely poor households as of mid-2022, a minority of its intended target population. Cabinet approved a national land title certification scheme, with parliament's approval outstanding in September 2026.

Sectoral management information systems

More than 1,500 Sierra Leonean health facilities file weekly disease-surveillance reports through the DHIS2-based eIDSR system, at submission rates around 85% in mid-2025, while rural primary healthcare units record the care itself on paper.

Electronic medical records exist only through isolated donor-supported pilots in a few districts, with the national Digital Health Roadmap and the National Health Compact setting extension to all facilities as a 2030 target, and a National Health Information Hub was launched in January 2026. None of it reaches the foundational identity: the World Bank records that systems handling sensitive data such as child protection are not linked to the national ID and still rely on paper. Education is in the same position, with rural primary schools keeping attendance and enrolment on paper registers digitised afterwards by visiting enumerators and the local education management system LoMEMIS named among the systems awaiting a service bus that does not yet exist.

Revenue administration is the exception that works and the one that uses the identity number: the Integrated Tax Administration System is deployed nationwide as the taxpayer register, and its taxpayer numbers are issued against a National Identification Number. Customs runs ASYCUDA and the budget IFMIS, both standalone.

Justice has one working system and a blueprint for the rest. The judiciary's Justice App, a mobile case-management application piloted in the Freetown and Makeni courts from 2017, was reported to have disposed of 3,670 cases by 2022, and the Chief Justice said in April 2025 that it still runs beside a virtual court for witnesses abroad while some courts remain on paper. An e-Justice Blueprint launched in March 2025 frames the digitisation of case management, court processes and legal documentation, with a consulting team scoping the work as of May 2025 and court records exchanged with no other government system. The police's 2025-2029 strategic plan commits to moving from a paper-based to a digital records management system and to deploying e-Case Management from 2026, while a 2025 partnership with the Directorate of Science, Technology and Innovation digitises police human resource and payroll administration rather than case recording. On the employment side the Labour Market Information System runs as a standalone platform connected to no government-wide exchange. The health ministry issued the national digital health strategy for 2018 to 2023. A national digital jobs portal was launched on 27 August 2026, and a convergence workshop on the architecture of health digital public infrastructure was held on 17 and 18 September 2026.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The most substantial thing a Sierra Leonean can do online with the state is pay tax: the revenue authority runs the Integrated Tax Administration System nationwide with an online taxpayer portal, through which income tax and vehicle tax are filed and paid by mobile money and wallet.

Beyond tax, a ministry app is the main channel. WanGov launched in February 2025 to take applications, documents and payments for services including business registration, tax filing, permits and driving licences, and was deployed at the Gbalamuya border post with Guinea in October 2025; no usage figure is published.

Business users get less. The Office of the Administrator and Registrar-General offers an online business-name search on a register that is only partially digitised. Parliament ratified a 15-year build-operate-transfer concession for an online business registration system in May 2026, and the investment board's platform was reported nearly complete in October 2026, with November given as its operational date. The land register behind property transactions remains largely paper. Passports, work and residence permits, driving licences and vehicle registration are gated on the identity number. The electronic government procurement platform's supplier registration module was live by January 2026, with the platform hosted in the Ministry of Finance data centre ahead of full rollout, and the National Public Procurement Authority sent a delegation to Liberia on 6-7 August 2026 to study that country's electronic government procurement platform.

Coordination is centralised on paper: government digital solutions go through a Digital Service Compliance review process run by the Ministry of Communication, Technology and Innovation. The systems that watch the rest of government are themselves unfinished. SierraSeat, the audit management system built for Audit Service Sierra Leone as a World Bank-funded customisation of AFROSAI-E's A-SEAT to run planning, supervision, documentation, reporting and follow-up end to end, was in the last stage of user acceptance testing and not in production as at 11 August 2026. The National Monitoring and Evaluation Agency is expanding a platform giving authorised personnel real-time metrics on public projects, and its director-general acknowledges continuing rollout problems with data entry and reporting. A platform to hold ministerial performance contracts, targets and quarterly progress reports in one reporting system was shown to ministries in October 2026 and awaits validation, testing and implementation.

Measured readiness sits in the bottom fifth of countries on the UN E-Government Development Index (2024), and equal access to public services has fallen since 2014 into the country's ten most deteriorated Ibrahim Index measures. The build behind the front end is externally financed, through the World Bank's Digital Transformation Project and the regional WARDIP2 approved in March 2026, with a National Data Centre commissioned at the communications regulator's headquarters in April 2026. What the state runs it mostly does not show: the monitoring platform is for authorised personnel, and the payment switch's rules are issued as directives without a consolidated public rulebook.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Sierra Leone's councils appear in the design of the national data exchange before they appear in any working part of it: the systems named for connection to the planned Government Service Bus include the local education management system LoMEMIS and the Municipal Property Tax System covering 22 local councils, alongside civil registration, the Integrated Tax Administration System and the central bank's core banking platform (2025) — the scope of a bus that has still to be built. The sub-national digitalisation that does exist is concentrated in the capital and a handful of urban centres. Freetown City Council has run a digital address register built on Google Plus Codes since its 2019-2020 property tax reform, identifying buildings that have no conventional street address (2024), and the Directorate of Science, Technology and Innovation agreed a partnership with Google Maps in 2024 to digitise addresses more widely, though deployment stays in urban centres (2024). The World Bank-financed Digital Transformation Project is extending broadband to local government offices in secondary cities (2025).

Where sub-national government has moved furthest is political rather than technical: rural representation and participation rose 24.1 points over 2014-2023 to 69.3 out of 100, 24th of 54 African states and one of the country's ten most improved measures (2023).

Rural digital data capture

The largest body of rural data in Sierra Leone joined to a foundational system is the national farmer registry, whose records are being authenticated against the national identification number to strip out duplicate farmers (May 2025). Very little else recorded in a rural facility reaches a database. Rural primary schools keep attendance, enrolment and administrative data on paper registers and forms, and the Annual School Census questionnaire is filled in on paper by the head teacher and digitised afterwards by a visiting enumerator on a tablet (2024); a tablet application letting school leaders record attendance directly reaches only a small minority of government primary schools, and its planned expansion has not been procured (2024). Health facilities report disease surveillance electronically, on devices serviced nationwide in mid-2025, a system that has moved surveillance off paper since 2019 (2025), and the police's 2025-2029 plan still has the move from paper-based to digital records management ahead of it, with a digital case management system due from 2026.

What stops the capture is power and connection, not software. Rural electricity access remains a fraction of urban access (2023), the fibre backbone now reaches all but a couple of districts without reaching most of the people inside them (2026), and the government acknowledges that the rural-urban divide in connectivity and the price of data are unresolved (April 2026). The World Bank-financed Digital Transformation Project is extending broadband to schools, hospitals and health clinics in underserved rural areas (2025), and solar home systems are being financed for schools and health facilities to give them the electricity digital services need (2025).

The rural economy the data would serve is improving slowly and losing ground on markets: it scores 57.4 out of 100 and ranks 30th of 54 African states, up 2.4 points in a decade, with rural economy support at 69.9 and rural land and water access at 58.9, up 14.8 points, while rural market access has fallen over the same decade (2023). The civil registration authority holds that registration has to be decentralised into rural and underserved communities as well as digitalised if the register is ever to be complete (August 2026).

Technology

AI

Sierra Leone had no national artificial-intelligence strategy in force as at May 2026, and its attorney-general told a UNESCO forum in September 2026 that it has no AI-specific statute either, and will treat AI systems affecting citizens' rights as high-risk by default. The Ministry of Communication, Technology and Innovation is drafting the first strategy alongside the World Bank, after a readiness diagnostic reported complete by September 2026, and three-day multi-stakeholder consultations set on reflecting the country's own languages and cultural contexts in whatever is eventually adopted. Both are work of the drafting rather than provisions of an instrument, and they sit inside the government's medium-term development plan and the president's "Big Five Game Changers", led by the ministry with the Directorate of Science, Technology and Innovation.

One system runs inside government: a machine-learning tool allocating national stocks of more than 70 essential medicines, scaled nationwide after a five-district pilot (June 2026, on its developers' own figures). The education ministry's EDITH assistant for officials was built by March 2026 and is being prepared for handover from pilot, while the ten to fifteen AI-driven government workflows undertaken with the Kenyan firm Qhala under a memorandum signed at the 80th UN General Assembly are commitments rather than working systems. What has been delivered is training: senior officials from across ministries, departments and agencies took AI foundations and emerging-technology courses in March 2026, and the civil-service digital skills programme launched in July 2026 counts AI and automation among its six areas.

In citizen-facing services the technology so far belongs to private firms rather than to the state, a fintech WhatsApp assistant launched in April 2026 being the visible case. The state's own encounter with it is defensive: a nationwide deepfake and misinformation awareness campaign led by the Directorate of Science, Technology and Innovation has been running since May 2026, with no legislative or platform-facing instrument beside it, and the next phase it has announced, an AI-powered verification chatbot among it, has not been built. A national campaign on deepfakes and digital misinformation was launched in Freetown on 16 September 2026, in two phases across all 16 districts, and a national AI roadmap for the justice sector was announced after a justice-sector convening, reported 5 October 2026.

ICT Industry

The rules the sector trades under got worse while the economy around it widened: business and competition regulations fell 5.3 points to 56.7 out of 100 in the Ibrahim Index, 21st of 54 African states, even as economic diversification rose 21.5 points to 72.7 and 14th (2023), with the business and labour environment overall at 41.5

and 34th of 54. Technology and innovation were added to a ministry that had been communications alone, less than a year old in early 2024 and with no structures in place to handle them. It builds on a business base that is largely outside the formal register and on an electricity supply that fails for a large part of each month.

Innovation ecosystem

Sierra Leone is not assessed at all in the WIPO Global Innovation Index 2024, excluded from the 133 economies ranked because too few of the index's input and output indicators exist for the country — an absence of measurement rather than a low score. Money is the constraint underneath that: the startup hubs, principally Innovation SL and the Orange Digital Center, together facilitated around USD 1.7m in grants and investment between 2022 and 2024, with formal angel investment minimal and most entrepreneurs working from personal savings (2025). Angel investment infrastructure appeared only at the end of 2025, when a Sierra Leone angel network was formed. The hub layer those founders pass through is small and long-standing: nine active technology hubs were counted at the end of 2020.

New things do reach the market. An open-access 5G standalone network launched in June 2025, and a multi-currency digital wallet paired with a merchant payment stack launched in April 2025 — both private builds, neither the product of a public innovation programme. Four submissions to the global digital public goods registry were announced on 24 September 2026, and a Startup Act is expected in the first quarter of 2027, stated 12 September 2026.

Capacity

Literacy

Adult digital and financial literacy in Sierra Leone scores 26 out of 100 (2025), the composite from the first national baseline survey of the two together, and that is the floor every digital service in the country is being designed against.

Schooling itself has improved sharply, and unevenly in a particular direction. Education is the single largest driver of the country's decade of governance improvement, rising 15.4 points over 2014–2023 to 60.6 out of 100 and 15th of 54 African states, and enrolment reached 62.1 and 6th of 54 (2023) after a 23.7-point rise that is among the country's ten most improved measures. What happens after a child is enrolled is a different story: completion scored 48.1 and 21st of 54, and education quality 44.5 and 26th of 54 (2023) — both up over the decade, both far below the number of children getting through the door.

Public campaigning has moved to the newer risk. Since May 2026 the Directorate of Science, Technology and Innovation, MoCTI and the Sierra Leone Digital Transformation Project have run a nationwide deepfake and digital-misinformation awareness campaign, which by July 2026 had reached Freetown, Makeni, Port Loko, Magburaka, Bo, Kenema and Kono and convened Paramount Chiefs, district officials, security institutions, councils and universities.

The physical conditions for learning anything digital in a classroom are still being assembled: World Bank financing is paying for solar home systems in 500 schools and 200 health facilities (December 2025).

Training and skills

In July 2026 Sierra Leone launched a Digital Skills Programme for the civil service, run by MoCTI with the Ministry of Public Administration and Political Affairs, the Civil Service Training College and the Human Resource Management Office, aiming at 1,000 civil servants in year one, 3,000 in the medium term and more than 5,000 in the long term. It sits under the Digital Skills Development and Gig Economy Pipeline (2025–26) and covers six areas, among them AI and automation and cybersecurity.

What has actually been delivered is smaller and more senior than those targets. MoCTI, the Directorate of Science, Technology and Innovation, the National Cybersecurity Coordination Centre and the Kenyan firm Qhala trained more than 50 senior leaders from across ministries, departments and agencies in March 2026, in digital literacy, the national-security implications of emerging technology and AI foundations; the whole-of-government AI and cybersecurity effort follows a partnership with Qhala entered in September 2025. A Spatial Data Science for Development workshop trained 60 Sierra Leonean leaders in GIS and remote sensing, hazard mapping and secure inter-agency data governance for disaster management and WASH planning in June 2026, and Audit Service Sierra Leone, with AFROSAI-E, trained 25 staff on the final configured build of its SierraSeat audit management system over 3–5 August 2026.

The pipeline those programmes draw on is thin and only recently connected. Twelve universities have been connected to the internet via Starlink through the local partner ELCOME SL under the National Broadband Strategy 2023–2028 (January 2025), with extension to vocational schools named as the next step. They sit on a small public tertiary base in ICT and engineering and feed the modest technology hub sector UNESCO recorded before the pandemic.

Research institutions

Knowledge production in computing and engineering rests on a small number of public institutions: the University of Sierra Leone, whose Fourah Bay College awards degrees in electrical, electronic, mechanical and civil engineering, and Njala University. Neither the scale of that output nor Sierra Leone's public spending on research and development had been published as at August 2026.

The Center for Information Privacy, Human-Centered Technology and Ethics Research launched in Freetown on 6 October 2026 to research the handling of personal data, train on data-subject rights and feed evidence into data-protection law and policy.

Inclusion

Access to services

Equal access to public services in Sierra Leone is going backwards: the measure has fallen 9.5 points since 2014 to 45.9 out of 100, 22nd of 54 African states, and is among the country's ten most deteriorated (2023). Social safety nets score worse still, at 18.5 out of 100 and 45th of 54, down 4.1 points over the same decade and among the ten worst measures the country records (2023). Provision has not followed what has been built.

The encounter that decides most of this is the one at the registration counter. Citizens' own sense of how easy it is to obtain an identity document has deteriorated sharply since 2014, even as enrolment has climbed. Part of the reason is geography: civil registration and ID issuance stay concentrated at district headquarters, and through 2025 parliamentarians, community leaders and registration officers pressed the National Civil Registration Authority to push services down to chiefdom level, given the distances rural residents travel to register a birth. The authority now says itself that the register cannot be completed without decentralisation alongside digitalisation (August 2026).

Digitalisation has not removed the people who stand between a citizen and the register. Those without papers still reach it through chiefs, teachers and justices of the peace, whose affidavits the registration authority accepts — an arrangement that keeps people out of statelessness while leaving someone else to decide who counts as belonging.

Where services reach people, the channel is usually a mobile wallet, not a bank or government counter. For much of the rural population the wallet is the first formal financial service they have held, not a substitute for a bank account. Non-nationals, refugees and migrants reach payment accounts the same way, and the International Organization for

Migration signed a partnership with Orange Money in August 2024 to route payments to migrants and displaced people through it. The state's own side is only starting: the flagship social assistance programme is shifting its transfers to digital payment (December 2025). Policy meanwhile commits that cognitive, mental, literacy or physical ability should not exclude anyone from digital services, and makes accessibility a design requirement. One hundred inmates were registered for national identification numbers on 17 September 2026.

Digital divides

The government's own position, put on the record in April 2026, is that the rural-urban divide in connectivity and the high cost of data remain unresolved. The gender line has not been measured since the 2015 census, which found 16% of men and 10% of women aged 10 and over with internet access: Sierra Leone was not among the fifteen countries surveyed individually for GSMA's 2025 mobile gender gap report, which puts the gap across sub-Saharan Africa at 29% in 2024, down from 32% in 2023 and 36% in 2022. A country that concedes the divide has no current national number for one of its main axes. Rural build-out runs through the universal access fund, whose rural telephony project, launched in five communities in 2024, reports connecting about 47,700 people in 114 localities; the fund lives on a 0.75% levy on mobile operators and asked Parliament in August 2025 to raise it to 1%.

The sharpest exclusion is not between the registered and the unregistered but inside the register itself. Most adults now hold a national identification number, yet only a small fraction of them hold the card that proves it, because enrolment is free and the physical eID card is not. Being on the register and being able to demonstrate it are two different conditions, and the second one has a price. The people least able to meet it are the same people whose claim on the state most often has to be proved to someone.

Beneath that sits a floor that most digital services assume away. Digital literacy scores far below the level those services take for granted, access to internet and computers remains among the country's ten worst-scoring governance measures despite a decade of improvement, and access to banking is the lowest-scoring of all ninety-six measures in that index. Rural households are far less likely to have electricity than urban ones, which sets a limit no handset subsidy reaches. And the constraint on take-up is affordability rather than coverage: the network reaches people the tariff does not. The national AI strategy at least treats local languages and cultural context as a design question rather than an afterthought, which is more than most of the service estate does.

Data

National statistics

The capacity of Sierra Leone's statistical system gained 21.9 points over 2014-2023 to reach 53.7 out of 100, 22nd of 54 African states (2023), the largest improvement on any of the country's public administration measures. What it is built on is thinner. On the World Bank's 2023 Statistical Performance Indicators the country sits in the 20-49% band for both data sources and data infrastructure, its two weakest pillars, while data use and data products fall in the 70-89% band and data services between the two. It is better at using and packaging statistics than at producing them.

The counting is kept up unevenly. A population census and a census of business establishments have both been run within the past ten years, but no agricultural census in the past twenty (2023), and that census found most establishments informal. The survey programme tilts the same way: three or more agricultural surveys and three or more health surveys over the decade, against two household surveys and one labour force survey (2023). Separately, the Bank of Sierra Leone and the UN Capital Development Fund publish a recurring State of the Digital Financial Services Market report covering accounts, transactions and participants, with editions for 2019, 2020, 2021 and 2024.

Administrative data cannot fill the gaps. Annual School Census questionnaires are still completed on paper by school heads and digitised afterwards by visiting enumerators (2024), and the health system's DHIS2-based disease surveillance carries weekly aggregate reporting rather than individual records (2025). What does produce data is not joined up: the Labour Market Information System runs as a standalone platform with no government-wide exchange to connect to (2025). Vital statistics are split: birth registration measured high in the 2019 survey round while the death side lags far behind, and the National Public Health Agency has been assessing mortality data capability (August 2026). Until the National Monitoring and Evaluation Agency was created, no dedicated body tracked what became of the public projects parliament approved (August 2026), and the record is thin enough that the country is absent from the WIPO Global Innovation Index 2024 for want of indicators. Census Night is set for 1 December 2026, and the statistics office put the census budget at nearly US$60 million in October 2026, against an initial estimate of US$7 million; and the draft 2025 Vital Statistics Report was under stakeholder validation on 10 and 11 September 2026. The statistics agency deployed the technology for the digital census, with enumeration by tablet set for 2 to 16 December 2026.

Open data

Nothing Sierra Leone publishes scores well. In Open Data Watch's 2024 Open Data Inventory the country's strongest categories — the built environment, gender statistics and health outcomes — reach 6.0 out of 10, and no category scores higher (2024). At the other end, crime and justice statistics are the weakest scored category at 2.0, with health facilities data next lowest at 3.0 (2024), and energy, pollution, international trade and communications and digital data carry no score at all (2024). Finance is the exception that proves the pattern: the central bank's recurring digital financial services market report puts account, transaction and participant numbers into public view in a way no other sector matches.

The state's own disclosure has barely moved in a decade. Sierra Leone scores 31.9 out of 100 for disclosure of public records, 32nd of 54 African states, and 35.0 for accessibility of public records, 19th of 54, having gained 0.5 and 4.9 points respectively over 2014-2023 (2023). A middling rank on measures that have stayed flat says as much about the region as it does about the country.

Publication runs through the 2013 access-to-information Act, under which the statistics office keeps a scheme listing 22 classes of information it releases routinely, its publications, metadata and microdata free of charge (2024). The Data Protection and Right to Access Information Bill 2025 completed its final national validation in November 2025 and would create a single independent authority for both data protection and access to information. Where publication duties do exist they are narrow. The National Payment Systems Act 2022 requires the central bank directives that govern the national switch to appear in the Gazette or on the Bank's website before they take effect, and no consolidated public rulebook exists. Regional commitments are thinner still in public: the ECOWAS Digital Sector Development Strategy 2024-2029 stands on the record through the ministerial release announcing its adoption at Cotonou on 4 October 2024, which names the instrument without setting out what it requires of a member state.

Use of satellite data

Sierra Leone's geospatial work took its first institutional shape in mid-2026, and it came through a partnership rather than a state body. The Directorate of Science, Technology and Innovation and Catholic Relief Services signed a memorandum of understanding on geospatial technology in June 2026, under which a Coordination and Visualization Platform for geospatial data was set to launch the following month (June 2026), alongside a spatial data science workshop training government leaders in GIS, remote sensing and hazard mapping for disaster management and water and sanitation planning (June 2026). No national space or geospatial agency, ground receiving facility, or space or geospatial data policy had been established as at August 2026.

Satellite services otherwise reach the country as procurement rather than capability. Starlink launched in Sierra Leone in June 2024 and the regulator counts it as licensed and two years in operation (March 2026), and the government has used it to connect universities under the National Broadband Strategy (January 2025). The clearest operational use of geospatial data is in land: under the Sierra Leone Land Administration Project a firm has been recruited to build the land information and cadastral system and records digitisation is under way, with no public digital cadastre in operation (2026).

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The American position in Sierra Leone's digital systems is grid control rather than platforms, connectivity or cloud: the Millennium Challenge Corporation's compact pays for a main and back-up distribution dispatch centre for the Electricity Distribution and Supply Authority and a national dispatch centre with SCADA upgrades, giving the utilities centralised visibility of the network. The operational technology of the electricity system is therefore where the United States holds a position; no American platform, cloud or network-equipment presence in government systems is on the record.

China activities

China both financed and built Sierra Leone's inland fibre: China Eximbank lent RMB 207 million on concessional terms in August 2019 for Phase 2 of the National Fibre Optic Backbone Infrastructure Project, a 721.5 km network reaching 15 cities across the northern, eastern and southern regions. The Ministry of Finance on-lent the money to SALCAB, the state backbone company that owns the result, and Huawei was the engineering, procurement and construction contractor. The backbone the country's traffic runs on is thus a Chinese-financed, Chinese-built asset in Sierra Leonean state hands.

EU activities

European money sits inside the civil registration system rather than beside it: the European Union committed EUR 5 million over 2020-2025 to the IT and physical infrastructure of civil registration, aimed at lifting birth and death registration through register service centres and the issue of document extracts to citizens. The second European commitment is much smaller and sits in agriculture, EUR 1 million over 2022-2025 for a block-farming and digital extension platform in a pineapple supply chain, placing 250 farmers on half-acre plots of a 50-hectare block farm with targets of 20-30% women and 40-50% youth. No standing EU bilateral digital agreement, and no European platform or equipment presence in government systems, is on the record.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf-financed digital infrastructure, Emirati or Saudi platform presence, and no Gulf bilateral digital agreement was on the record for Sierra Leone as at August 2026.

India activities

No India Stack-derived deployment, Indian digital financing or bilateral digital agreement was on the record for Sierra Leone as at August 2026.

Digital sovereignty

President Bio told a UN General Assembly roundtable on 21 September 2026 that Sierra Leone has been exploring regional data embassies, under which critical public data would be hosted in another participating state while the country keeps legal jurisdiction and control over it, on the principle that "sovereignty should travel with the law, not simply with the building".

Cabinet approved a National Open Source Software First Policy in July 2026, aimed at cutting software costs, improving data security and strengthening digital sovereignty. The next identity platform rests on a memorandum with Bhutan's national digital identity company and the Sign Foundation, built on open-source technology and W3C verifiable credentials, stressing local capability and long-term national ownership (July 2026), which builds on a November 2025 memorandum under which the California-based Sign leads development of "sovereign blockchain infrastructure" for national identity, a wallet and asset tokenisation.

State data sits in state facilities: the civil registration authority hosts identity data in its own Tier-3 data centre and offers hosting to ministries (2024), and the government data centre is at the NatCA tower, with a redundancy site planned at State House and a data governance framework being drafted to set how government data is classified, shared and used (September 2026). Owning a facility has not meant running it: the auditor found that the Universal Access Development Fund's central data centre was managed and controlled exclusively by a foreign contractor, the fund having no administrative access to the system (2024). No instrument fixing where state data is held or under whose law it is processed was in force as at September 2026.

The health agreement with the United States commits the government to protecting data sovereignty and regulatory authority under a US$129m memorandum signed on 22 December 2025, and its text and related data-sharing agreements are among those a US freedom-of-information suit filed in April 2026 seeks to have the State Department release. The terms on which the Sign Foundation agreements and the Universal Access Development Fund's data-centre contract govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026.

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